

space might do a lot for your avarice, but only if you were undisciplined about regularly looking after your e-mail account would you care for that much space. And knowing the adage that 'data expands to fill up space', even 20 MB might soon be insufficient.

Among the e-mail service providers that we looked at, Geek.com and Lycosasia offer 20 MB space. (You know the competition in India is heating up when you realise that Lycos, as opposed to Lycosasia, offers only 6 MB). Geek goes a step further to add to your greed by providing for POP3 access to their account, which means that you can download messages using your e-mail client. The same is true for Myrealbox.com, which offers 10 MB space and POP3 and IMAP access. Guess these sites take the notion of 'Yeh dil maange more' to heart!

However, aside from providing you with storage space, many sites put a cap on the size of e-mail attachments that you can receive. Geek, for instance, has a cap of 5 MB as the attachment size that you send. Indiatimes.com, with its 10 MB storage space, allows you to send e-mails up to a maximum of 1.5 MB per message, though there seems to be no bar on the size of

attachments that you can receive. Similarly, Email.com provides 10 MB storage space, but here you can send and receive e-mails only up to 2 MB. Yahoo.co.in pegs the limit at around 1.5 MB, Chequemail.com at 3.5 MB while Hotmail.com puts a limit of 1 MB. So, if your work involves sending a number of large attachments, then you should probably opt for Geek or Myrealbox, or maybe keep a file splitter handy!

Speeding it up

One look at the e-mail services, and you wouldn't need a data log or a timer to tell you that Indiatimes and Rediffmail.com are really fast. Whether in terms of receiving e-mail, sending e-mail with attachments, or even viewing a JPEG image in the browser itself, there's a perceptible difference between these two and the rest. The reason, as we mentioned earlier, is that these sites are hosted in India itself, which provides a major speed difference.

Chequemail, which is also hosted in India, provides for good transfer speeds but tends to get bogged down by the banner-ads on the site that consume a lot of bandwidth. Other sites that are fast in terms of sending and receiving e-mail are Yahoo.co.in and Excite.com.

Say No to spam

The anti-spamming features that Hotmail provides are truly great. You can choose to block senders and also known domain names. You can also set up an exclusive list wherein only those present in your address book can send messages to you and at the same time have an exception list, called the safe list, for this exclusive list. This safe list would comprise of those persons in your exclusive list that you would also like to block. The site lets you protect your mailing lists and also set up 11 additional filters or rule-sets. While



Get greedy at Geek.com with 20 MB space

TOP 5

Our preferences for the five best e-mail service sites:

- Hotmail.com
- Yahoo.co.in
- Indiatimes.com
- Myrealbox.com
- Geek.com and Rediffmail.com

www.thinkdigit.com

Who's your favourite? Vote for them at
www.thinkdigit.com/reviews/free_email

Read the Fine Print

Most people click on the I Accept button on the Terms and Conditions page with the same lackadaisical attitude as when they say, "I Do" at the altar. They don't realise what they're getting into, until after disaster strikes!

Here's a sampling of some of the terms and conditions for using the e-mail services. Chequemail, for instance, has clearly spelt-out anti-spamming policies. Such is their wrath against spammers that, if caught, they charge you Rs 25 for each mail! For that matter, you are liable for \$5 even with Hotmail, if damage due to spamming is proven.

If you read Hotmail's Terms and Condi-

tions carefully, it clearly states that you cannot have a Hotmail account for company purposes ('You may not use your MSN Hotmail address as your primary business address'). So, if your company e-mail address is something like yourcompany-name@hotmail.com, you are clearly violating their terms of use.

Most sites provide for adequate spam protection and agree to safeguard your privacy. Most of the terms and conditions clearly specify that you cannot use the accounts for unlawful purposes such as e-mailing serial numbers and cracks. Sites such as Hotmail, Yahoo.co.in, Excite, etc, have adopted the Truste privacy statement.

This is a kind of endorsement from a third-party organisation, wherein the e-mail service provider agrees to abide by certain rules such as not providing your personal information to advertisers or not allowing users below the age of 13 to register.

Of course, in spite of all the terms of use and privacy policy statements, the bottom line is that the service is always provided on an 'as is where is' basis, with no claims possible if the site isn't up. And Indiatimes even says that it maintains the right to ask users to pay for the service at a later date ('This site reserves the right to charge subscription or membership fees'). So, what was the free stuff all about?!